

Contemporary African Politics
FINAL EXAM

1. You work as an assistant to the finance minister in a developing country, where annual aid is roughly 26% of GDP & HIV is 35% of the adult population. Your minister recognizes the importance these outside funds play in paying for education, health and infrastructure but wonders whether there are deleterious effects of so much aid to African countries. Drawing on region-specific case evidence from your class lectures, slides and readings, and in addition to your own regional contextual knowledge, please discuss the possible benefits and costs of high dependency on foreign aid, and ways they could maximize the benefits of aid while mitigating the ill effects. (10)

As suggested in its name, foreign aid can be an extremely beneficial element for all sorts of countries (not just developing countries). In general, foreign aid can help in states of emergencies such as natural disasters, infrastructure failure, drought, and famine. However, in developing nations foreign aid has an exponential power to do good but also extreme harm. Developing nations, particularly former colonized or exploited nations by colonizing nations. Their past history of colonization included an exploitation and disruption of original and natural proceedings which used the natural resources available to native citizens in order to support the nation. Colonizers exploited not only the people of the colonies but their natural resources as well, making it harder for post-colonial nations to build necessary infrastructure to mitigate chaos from disasters and ultimately more susceptible to things like drought and famine. Therefore, for nations like these, foreign aid is more heavily relied on.

Dependence on foreign aid in nations which are already made vulnerable by colonialism could have several catastrophic results. Minister, considering our nation's GDP comes from foreign aid, I urge you to take caution of the following negative effects of foreign aid. First, a constant high in-flow of foreign aid can encourage corruption and weaken the government system already in place. This is particularly problematic for young nations. Large sums of foreign aid and the lack of transparency surrounding what happens to that money after it is donated can incentivize political leaders to run for office, not for the good of the country but for the possibility of skimming off the top of the aid given to the nation. This doesn't allow for newer nations to build strong governments as their leaders are motivated by a financial gain instead of a commitment to the nation.¹

Another thing I urge you to watch out for are the conditions which this aid comes with. A common misconception about aid is that it is a grant. This is not the case. Oftentimes aid is given to nations in the form of loans with unfair interest rates. Because of our high dependence of foreign aid, we are already in a position to be desperate enough to accept loans with unfair/predatory interest rates. This situation further exacerbates our dependence on foreign nations as the interest rates of our loans could be just as economically crippling as the cause for the initial cause for aid. Again, this vulnerable state that this type of aid leaves us in also leaves us in a position to allow for these nations to further exploit our natural resources in order to repay their loans. Conditions for aid however can go beyond interest rates. One of our national crises which we may need to depend on foreign aid to remedy is our HIV levels in the adult population. Considering we have 35% of our adult population is HIV positive, you might be interested in accepting foreign aid to help address this issue. However, I urge you to review the conditions of this aid. In the past aid sent to help with the HIV crisis in Africa came with the condition that the nation may only teach abstinence only prevention for HIV. Instead of helping address the crisis, conditions like these can spread misinformation and allow for the crisis to continue, especially because despite how much abstinence is advocated for, people will still continue to engage in sex.

Above I've pointed out some of the many threats which come with dependency on foreign aid, however, considering we are already so dependent on it, it is not the best solution to simply stop accepting the aid. There are ways of mitigating the negative effects. First, I would suggest we implement strict transparency policies to monitor the distribution of aid. In order to maintain accountability from political leaders, this transparency system must be enforced by a judicial system that is separate from the legislative part of the government. Another helpful measure would be to target accepting aid which focuses on efforts which lead to independence from aid. For example, micro loan policies for small businesses have been proven to be very effective in jump starting independent economies. Similarly, infrastructure focused aid (building trains, energy sources). Although it is unrealistic to immediately thwart foreign aid, we should use our current aid to work towards independence from foreign aid.

¹ This is from one of the readings on corruption. I just cannot for the life of me remember the author's name. Sorry!

2. At the heart of this class is the African journey towards democracy and or majority rule. Drawing from 4 countries (pick any listed here (or not) -Zimbabwe, Ghana, South Africa, Rwanda, Uganda, Mozambique, Botswana, Nigeria) (10)
- a. Can you describe the major challenges for democracy in Africa?
 - i. One of the most obvious threats to democracy in Africa is corruptions. Although it is heavily associated with Africa, its direct correlation with democracy can be unclear. The high rates of corruption makes it so that the essential decisions of the nation are made by international/outside influences and the elites of the nation instead of the citizens of the nation (e.g. Zuma-former president of South Africa)
 - ii. Another common challenge brought up as a challenge to democracy is lack of access to voting infrastructure or technology, causing citizens in cities to be more likely to vote and an overrepresentation of urban opinions in matters which affect the entire nation. However, the extent to which this is an independent challenge or a tool used by politicians to suppress votes is up for debate. Yes, there are many new technologies used by first world nations which make voting easier and are not accessible to all african nations. However, there are also traditional methods such as physical ballots which are a lot more accessible and implementable by African leaders which are expressly not being used. So maybe the real threat to democracy here is the amount of control political leaders have in these decisions and the lack of accountability for not implementing democratic measures.
 - iii. Similarly the amount of absolute power politicians have in African nations also leads to lack of healthy opposition. All democracies require healthy opposition. However, the authoritative power of African politicians allows them to unfairly silence opposition.
 - iv. A lot of the time African politicians will run on platforms which cater to the largest (or most powerful) ethnic group in the nation. They are therefore only accountable, if that, to one part of the nation, actively working against the democracy of the nations.
 - b. Why was democracy successful in some countries but not others?
 - i. Successfully implementing democracy goes further than committing to it through a constitution. Several post-colonial nations began with a commitment to democracy but then turned autocratic and this is due to a myriad of factors. International influences are notorious for overthrowing democratic governments as it thwarts exploitative initiatives. Some internal factors also are needed like a foolproof democracy ensuring constitution: one that accounts for threats to democracy through checks and balances (e.g. US 3 part government). Additionally, the state of the nation's neighbors matters as well. It is much more difficult to be a democratic nation if your neighbors are actively working against democracy in their own nation (leads to stress on the nation from war).
 - c. Can you discuss the role of strong political institutions in democratic governance?
 - i. Strong political institutions are important because they create a system of accountability and instill trust in the population of the nation. Strong institutions require time to create. This is another reason why African nations struggle to implement democracy; their governments are very young and have high turnover rates. Impeachment is a sign of a strong political institution. For example, in the UK there's been a high turnover for prime ministers, however, this indicates that despite the position being one of the most powerful political positions, there still remains a system which allows for the people (or at least elected officials) to remove them. This makes it so that there is little opportunity for an individual to hold a disproportionate amount of power.

3. We have discussed the relationship between corruption and democratic governance. Drawing from readings, lectures, and group presentations (10)
 - a. Why is corruption a bigger problem for African Economies?
 - i. Corruption is a bigger problem for African Economies because of their already existing vulnerabilities. In any situation, a more vulnerable target will always suffer more than a stronger one. African Economies are often weak because of their forced dependence on foreign nations (e.g. through foreign aid, or forced lack of diversity, or monopolies over key economic goods by former colonizing nations). Lack of infrastructure is another cause of vulnerability. Every time a politician steals money from the people, that money was most likely meant for an essential piece of infrastructure: one that people's lives and livelihoods depended on. For example, if a Canadian politician were to steal funds for a new freeway, and the freeway was not actually built, this would be devastating for their constituents. However, its effect would not be as devastating as in certain African countries. In the case of the Canadian freeway, there are most definitely other ways in which the constituents could continue their everyday lives without the freeway. However, in some African nations, there may not be another road for the citizens to use.² The corruption therefore in Africa has a more devastating effect.
 - b. What are some citizens' daily experiences with corruption, and do these impact citizen engagement?
 - i. An example of a citizen's daily experience with corruption may be through explicit disparities in wealth in their country. Nations with high corruption have high economic disparities. A citizen may support a certain political candidate due to their appeal to their demographic and their promises to make their nation better. However, after electing this politician they might see no political or policy changes but instead the politician is flaunting their wealth online. Because African corruption can be so blatant, it makes the citizens feel like fools and further plays into the stereotyping of African nations as extremely corrupt. This ultimately leads to a sense of political hopelessness and therefore a lack of engagement in politics by citizens as they are most likely thinking "what's the point of engaging if all my efforts just lead to making people rich and not changing the country?"
 - c. If you could advise the new Zimbabwean president on addressing corruption what would you tell him to do to
 - i. Build citizen confidence in his government
 1. Increase transparency: By increasing transparency, the government is giving the people the opportunity to build trust in the institution. If the people can actively see what resources are going into the government and how they are maximizing it to benefit the citizens, they will gain confidence in the government.
 2. Education: This is a slippery slope as it can easily be misinterpreted as indoctrination. However, teaching the youth about what the government does and how the system works will make them more likely to contribute to it in the future. And, in general, if the people are more engaged in the government they are also more likely to have confidence in it as well.
 - ii. Investor confidence?
 1. Promote stability: one of the most important things that investors look at when choosing where to put their money is stability. Although, again this is a slippery slope because at times the good of the people will be sacrificed for the image of stability, by managing the image of their country as a stable and trustworthy place to invest in, the Zimbabwean government could increase their attractiveness to investors. An example of this is what is the current state of Rwanda. Following the Rwandan genocide, this became all of what Rwanda was known for. Their history of devastating war and instability made them an unlikely place for investors to engage with. However, the current president has put a tremendous amount of effort into changing the image of Rwanda as a place of peace and has thus received a lot western support.

² Not my original example: from class discussion

4. In class, we discussed that poverty affects men and women differently (10).
 - a. What do we mean when we say that poverty is gendered?
 - i. In short, when we say poverty is gendered we mean that it affects people differently based on their gender. Or more specifically, it affects minority genders more than others. This is because the way in which people contribute to the economy/support the economy differs based on their gender. For example women who don't have jobs contribute to the economy through unpaid labor. When women in families stay at home to maintain a household and raise children they are still contributing to the economy in a monumental way. Making food, cleaning a house, taking care of children, teaching them societal norms is all labor which they do not get paid for. Women if they do have jobs are more likely to work in jobs which require less education as there is limited access for them. These types of jobs typically have worse working conditions and therefore are not as protected. Additionally, the type of work that women do to support the economy is determined by what men deem not worthy of themselves. So whenever there is a shortage of workers (such as in war) women have to make up for the change. Because of all these examples of how gender affects how individuals contribute to the economy, an effect on poverty also follows.
 - b. What factors make it difficult for women to get out of poverty
 - i. As I mentioned above, the type of work women do is not as respected and therefore these jobs are less likely to have protection. Additionally, because women are expected to contribute to the economy through childcare and housework without compensation, it makes it harder for them to get jobs as they often have no time to work additional jobs. Because their default form of economic contribution is unpaid, they are systematically being worked against in any efforts to escape poverty.
 - ii. One of the most effective ways of getting out of poverty is through education. However, this is once again of limited accessibility for women due to their expected unpaid contributions and bias within education. In several families, women will only be given the opportunity to gain education past a certain level if all other male options in their family have been exhausted.
 - c. Discuss the factors that have in the last decades contributed to the empowerment of women and their participation in politics, in the informal and formal sectors of the economy?
 - i. One of the most significant factors which has led to more involvement of women in positions of power and the workforce in general is war. War depletes the traditional male workforce as they often die in combat, leaving their past jobs empty. This creates a space for women to take their positions. This also led to higher education levels of women. Because this gave women a position of power, it allowed them to make sure the door stayed open for women even after the male workforce returned to normal. Although the net benefits of this are not necessarily positive, the textile industry also contributed to the engagement of women in the workforce. Unlike other forms of physical labor such as mining which were not always deemed socially acceptable for women, textile work poses to be a safer option. Textile companies were therefore another opportunity for women to work and get paid for their work.

5. In class we have discussed that civil society plays an important role in African politics. (10)
 - a. Discuss the different definitions of civil society
 - i. Civil Society is composed of all the non-governmental political sectors which work towards improving the nation. More specifically, one where the citizens trust their government and the government works effectively on behalf of the citizens to justly and efficiently run their nation. Some things which are evidence of an effective civil society and also efforts which civil society work towards are the following. One essential factor is an independent justice system. The separation of the justice system and legislative system helps keep politicians accountable and therefore prevents threats to society such as corruption. Another key factor is the space for independent free media as it allows for opposition (a healthy component of society as it limits the excess of those in power and allows for citizens' opinions to be shared).
 - b. What role does civil society play in the democratizing states in Africa? In your discussion pay special attention to recent movements in Burkina Faso, Burundi or the #feesmustfall movement in South African universities.
 - i. Civil society creates the right environment for democracy to blossom. Trust in government and the engagement of the people to better the government are essential to enforcing democracy. The #feesmustfall movement is an example of how these exact things help enforce democracy. Students across the country protested the unfairly high prices of tuition and its increases. The net effect of the protest eventually led to a stop in increases for now. However, it is debatable whether this is an example of civil society and the government working together as it should. The protests were long and turned extremely violent, disrupting not only the flow of students receiving education but society in general. The movement is at the surface level an example of civil society working as the students used their voices
 - c. What are some of the challenges that civil society faces that limit their ability to influence political change?
 - i. At the end of day, civil society does not have legislative or judicial power. They're only means of change are financial or through advocacy. While these can be very powerful means, they still ultimately depend on the willingness of the government's involvement. No matter how much an organization throws money at a political issue or protest, the government is not guaranteed to reply.
 - ii. A threat to civil society is corruption as they can easily undermine their efforts. Similarly, censorship also poses a threat to civil society. As I mentioned above, one of the most powerful tools of civil society is advocacy as it allows for them to build support and strengthen the voice of the people. However, censorship can easily thwart this, taking out one of their most effective methods.

6. Conflict is one of the main challenges on the African continent (10):

- a. In what ways can a country's neighbor's influence that country's political trajectory?
 - i. Particularly in Africa, neighboring countries often include peoples of the same ethnic groups due to arbitrarily drawn national borders during colonialism. This means that in one nation the minority ethnic group may be the majority ethnic in their neighboring nation. This can lead to political issues as politics can use (and often do) use ethnicities to lift one group above another. In situations where the minority and majority of the same ethnic group are split into two, this can cause immediate ethnic conflict between nations. Another challenge which arises due to these borders are land claims. A country containing a majority ethnic group might try and make land claims based on their shared ethnicity. This can lead to border wars which are very common not only in Africa but across the world.
 - ii. Political ideology also has a way of spreading amongst neighbors. If your neighbor is democratic there is a really good chance that you will become democratic as well eventually. We see this in the western world with examples such as Canada and the US.
 - iii. The political state of neighboring countries also matters due to immigration. When a country is at war, refugees flee to neighboring nations. This affects politics as the issue of immigrants is always controversial. It creates a divide of opinion within the host nation about immigrants. Immigrants can be very helpful in boosting an economy as it provides a larger working base. However, it can also stress and drain a country of resources as well. Particularly countries that already do not have the infrastructure to support their existing population. This argument, however, is one that is abused as it does not apply in nations like the US which has an excess of resources and instead depends on immigrants to do exploitative labor. Regardless of the wealth of the host nation though, the introduction of a new immigrant group of peoples increases tensions and often leads to violence.
- b. Why are guns easily accessible in poor countries?
 - i. Although it may seem like Africans are too poor to have firearms, they've never really had to pay for them. All throughout colonialism, Africans have been armed by their colonizers to fight their wars for them. These included wars within the African nations and between african nations but also western wars such as WWII. These weapons were not simply thrown away or returned, they remained in the nation. Even in post-colonial nations, there still were western nations supplying arms as they were fighting proxy wars or those nations wanted to encourage the destabilization of African nations. For example, the British involvement in the Biafran war or the long lasting Somali-Ethiopian conflict in which Russia and the US have spent considerable efforts on both sides. Another reason is that international powers view conflicts in poor countries as an opportunity to make money. For example the Chinese supplying of axes in the Rwandan genocide. A more recent/relevant example of this is Viktor Bout who also sold illegal arms to African nations.
- c. If ethnic differences alone do not explain conflict- what are other causes of war/conflict?
 - i. Conflict arises out of an already existing vulnerability. For example, they are often caused by a lack of resources and a fight over who gets those resources. In nations where there are already enough resources and they are fairly distributed amongst their citizens, war is less likely to break out.
 - ii. Another key way in which conflict arises is through the politicization of differences. This is what people mostly misidentify as ethnicity being the cause of conflict. Instead the cause of conflict is the politicization of ethnicity. This can be done through several ways including spreading false and harmful narratives. The idea that only a politician from your ethnicity will look out for that group, or that if one ethnic group doesn't take power or a scarce resource then the other ethnicity will do so. These sort of narratives can be spread through the media by politicians.
 - iii. Wars can also be caused by the meddling of international powers/influences. For example, proxy wars in Africa. These were very common during the Cold War.

7. In 1994 the world watched while nearly one million people were killed by their neighbors and friends in the most heinous act of genocide in modern history. Discuss the genocide in Rwanda paying attention to the following (10):
 - a. What triggered the genocide?
 - i. Although there are several factors which cause conflicts such as these to come up. In the most literal sense, the violence began after a political figure was shot on his way to a peace treaty signing between the two Rwandan “ethnic” groups. The president of most of the government at the time was Hutu and his killing was disguised by extremists as a Tutsi act of war. This peace treaty was meant to remedy the tensions created and left by the French during colonialism (further explained in section b).
 - b. What are the historical (colonial and early post-colonial) factors that contributed to the environment for the 1994 genocide
 - i. This conflict was a direct result of the identities and tensions created by the French during colonialism. They arbitrarily created two ethnic groups out of one: the Tutsis and the Hutus based on things like features and height. During colonialism, the Tutsis were elevated over the Hutus by the French. They were given political power and spread the narrative that they were more beautiful, tall, and therefore more ethnically worthy of power over the Hutus. After the French left, they placed the Hutus in power instead of the Tutsis in order to ensure that the nation remained destabilized. The French essentially created a difference between a unified people, kindled hatred between them and then gave them all the power to act on that hatred. Although the genocide did not happen immediately after Rwandan independence, the genocide was a direct result of French colonial actions.
 - c. Name the key domestic and international players involved in the genocide?
 - d. What role did the media play in the conflict?
 - e. What was the response from the UN, US & Belgium?
 - i. The following is an answer for c, d, and e: International players in the genocide were China, France, and UN. China took advantage of the tensions to sell an immense amount of axes and weapons to the Hutu efforts. The axes became the primary weapon of massacre throughout the entire genocide. A key aspect of the genocide was that it was carried out by everyday people. Guns much more effectively kill people, however they are expensive, require ammunition and require skill. Axes, however, can be used by anyone to cause harm and are much cheaper. This is why China’s role in the genocide is not excuseable or insignificant. France was one of the few western nations to deploy troops. Not only did they deploy troops but they also trained and armed the Hutu government. However, it is unclear how helpful this exactly was in leading to peace as the genocide continued even in French occupied areas. (There is a tv series on netflix called “Black Earth Rising” that talks about the French/UN involvement in the Rwandan genocide from the perspective of a Rwandan refugee who was adopted by a British UN lawyer. It is really really well done.) The US involvement was mainly humanitarian relief for the Tutsi refugees. Again, the effectiveness of this involvement is heavily debated as the aid was much less than what was needed. The UN’s involvement is also heavily criticized as they refused to send in troops. Their policy is that they can not intervene unless their troops are shot at. Because this was a genocide targeted at the people of Rwanda, the UN “peace keepers” were not targeted.
 - ii. The main domestic players in the genocide were the existing Hutu government as well as Hutu and Tutsi extremists. The media was a particularly essential tool for the Hutu extremists. Directly following the death of the president, the message “cut down the tall trees” was broadcasted all across the nations radio as a signal to start the 100 days of genocide against the Tutsis. Even before the death of the president, the radio was an essential factor in spreading anti Tutsi messages and instilling more hatred towards the group. The radio was essentially primed the genocidaires to be able to commit the mass crime and violence they did in the 100 days of genocide.

8. Write an overall assessment of the course. What have you learned? In what way, if any, did the course help your understanding of African politics broadly defined? What is your biggest take away? What would you have liked to learn more about? (20)

African politics is often the main topic of discussion when gathered amongst other africans. Through family conversations at the kitchen table to discussions on the way to class, the topic of the political state and history of Africa is one that has never been an afterthought or ignored issue. However, I noticed that for so many others in the African diaspora with this shared experience this type of engagement with these politics is limiting. Although it is important for the state of Africa to not be ignored, exclusively being exposed to it through casual and conversational settings leaves a lot of space for biases and misunderstandings to take control of our conception of African politics. Additionally, it can create a false sense of knowing: one that allows you to assume you know everything on a topic exclusively through anecdotes or news catching headlines.

Probably one of the most important takeaways from this class was challenging this singular casual perspective of African politics that I've been predisposed to my entire life, and learning how to view and analyze African politics through a more analytical and more academic/critical lens. For example, the Rwandan genocide was a conflict that I learnt about earlier in life through my parents and films. While I was aware of the role in the French's former colonization in the conflict, my understanding of how else international influences and other influences propagated the genocide were limited: the supplying of axes from Chinese companies, the indifference of the UN, and the essential role of the radio as a vehicle for propaganda.

Similarly, analyzing issues which are famously associated with the weaknesses of Africa as a continent such as poverty, corruption and aids were of limited knowledge to me. These are elements which I'm pretty sure most people associate with Africa's downfalls, however, in this class I was able to analyze how exactly and why these elements are so problematic. Additionally, I learnt how to measure the effects of these issues through other statistical summaries of categorization of African demographics. For example, how poverty affects not only the GDP but the levels of HIV positive individuals, or how the age distribution of a continent correlates with the economic state of the country.

I found these types of tools and these types of lenses to be very helpful in understanding African political issues not only in this classroom but in my future discussion and exposure to African politics in general. More specifically, this has helped me critique and analyze my perspective on current issues in my country of origin: Ethiopia. There's been conflict in Ethiopia during my entire life and I've usually engaged with it exclusively through heavily biased discussions around the kitchen table. As a more knowledgeable and better equipped individual, I feel like I'm in a much better position to understand the elements which led to the current conflict as well as what to expect from the conflict. However, I would've also loved to learn more about conflict in Eastern Africa during this course. I know that Africa is a very large continent and that we only had one semester. I think it would have been really beneficial for me personally to learn more about eastern conflicts as they have affected my perception of Africa the most. I know that unlike Southern and Western African politics, it is not as well documented. I think it would've been really interesting to learn about Djibouti, for example, which had not one but two separations, from France and Ethiopia. Additionally, the ethnic/tribal conflicts in Somalia would have been interesting to look into as they've been split based on ethnicity despite being one of the most ethnically homogenous countries in Africa.

Again, I understand that everything about Africa can't be studied within one semester. I also learnt from this class how important Western and Southern African politics are in the history of Africa as they often shape the way in which we view African Politics. Overall, I really enjoyed this class and had a meaningful learning and classroom experience.